GOVERNMENT OF INDIA

Ministry of Education · Department of Higher Education

Ref. No. DHE/NMS/2026/01
Dated: 20 March 2026

National Merit Scholarship Scheme — Guidelines 2026

Effective from 1 April 2026

1. Introduction

1.1 Objective

The National Merit Scholarship Scheme provides financial assistance to meritorious students from economically weaker families to pursue full-time undergraduate studies at recognised institutions.

1.2 Supersession

These guidelines supersede the National Merit Scholarship Guidelines 2025 in their entirety. Applications for the academic year 2026-27 shall be governed only by these guidelines.

2. Eligibility Criteria

2.1 Income Criteria

The annual family income of the applicant from all sources must not exceed ₹2,50,000 (Rupees Two Lakh Fifty Thousand) per annum. Income shall be certified by a competent revenue authority not below the rank of Tehsildar.

2.2 Academic Criteria

The applicant must have secured at least 60% aggregate marks in the qualifying examination (Class XII or equivalent).

2.3 Age Limit

The applicant must be between 17 and 25 years of age as on 1 July 2026.

2.4 Mode of Study

The applicant must be enrolled in a full-time undergraduate programme at a recognised institution. Students enrolled in distance-learning programmes are eligible to apply under this scheme.

2.5 Other Scholarships

Students already receiving any other central or state government scholarship are not eligible.

3. Scholarship Benefits

3.1 Tuition Fee

Tuition fee reimbursement of up to ₹50,000 per academic year is paid directly to the institution.

3.2 Maintenance Allowance

A maintenance allowance of ₹1,500 per month is paid to the student for ten months in an academic year.

3.3 Exclusions

The scholarship does not cover examination fees, which remain the responsibility of the student.

4. Application Process

4.1 Mode of Application

Applications must be submitted online through the National Scholarship Portal. Physical applications will not be accepted.

4.2 Last Date

The last date for submission of applications is 31 July 2026.

4.3 Documents

Applicants must upload the documents listed in the Application Requirements notified by the Department.

5. Renewal

The scholarship is renewable annually, provided the student secures at least 55% marks in the previous year's examination and maintains a minimum attendance of 75%.

6. Disbursement

The scholarship amount is credited through Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) to the student's Aadhaar-seeded bank account only.

Any amount found to have been obtained on the basis of false information shall be recovered in full.